

StudentConnect

Your Gateway to Campus Events and Community

Group 2: Aleeza Ahmad, Berfu Emre,

Kashish Verma, Mustafa Omar, Oyku Cabuk

Course: PRJ566NBB – Project Planning and Management

Instructor: Behshid Behkamal

Date: January 18, 2026

Table of Contents

Table of Contents.....	2
Executive Summary.....	3
Problem Statement.....	3
Proposed Solution.....	3
Intended Impact.....	3
Value Proposition.....	4
"Never attend alone, discover campus events and the peers attending them."	4
Team Members and Roles.....	4
Project Overview & Background.....	4
Why Existing Solutions Fail.....	5
Problem Statement & Need.....	6
Objectives.....	6
Specific Project Goals.....	7
Deliverables.....	7
Why is this a Substantial Two-Semester Project?.....	8
Scope & Complexity.....	8
Phased Implementation Roadmap.....	8
Semester 1: Foundation & Core Architecture.....	8
● Phase 1: Planning & Design (Weeks 1-6).....	8
● Phase 2: Core Development (Weeks 7-14).....	8
Semester 2: Intelligence, Social Features & Optimization.....	9
● Phase 3: Advanced Logic Implementation (Weeks 1-7).....	9
● Phase 4: Analytics & Testing (Weeks 8-14).....	9
References.....	10

Executive Summary

Project Title: StudentConnect

Team Name: CodeConnect Solutions

Problem Statement

Seneca College students face significant barriers to campus engagement due to the fragmented nature of event communication across multiple platforms (Instagram, email, physical posters, and messaging apps), as well as social hesitation about attending events without peers. This fragmentation leads to low event attendance and contributes to student isolation, particularly affecting Seneca students who commute and have limited opportunities for spontaneous community building.

Proposed Solution

StudentConnect is a web-based event discovery and social connectivity platform designed specifically for Seneca College students. The application centralizes all campus events into a single searchable interface while providing social connection through peer attendance visibility. Key features include program-specific event filtering (CPA, BSD, etc.), real-time display of which peers have RSVP'd to events, private event creation for student-organized study groups and gatherings, and automated notifications for event reminders and updates. By combining event discovery with social connectivity, StudentConnect addresses both the awareness gap and the attendance barrier (communication gap) simultaneously.

Intended Impact

The platform aims to increase student event participation and facilitate new peer connections within the first academic year. By improving event visibility and reducing social barriers to attendance, StudentConnect is expected to positively impact student retention metrics, as research demonstrates that students attending 10+ campus events per semester are 13% more likely to carry on to the next semester (Modern Campus, 2025). The platform will

serve Seneca's 30,000+ student population across multiple campuses (Wikipedia, 2024) while providing administrators with engagement analytics to inform future programming decisions.

Value Proposition

"Never attend alone, discover campus events and the peers attending them."

Team Members and Roles

- **Backend Lead:** Mustafa Omar
- **Database Administrator/ Data Analyst:** Kashish Verma
- **Frontend Developer / UI Designer:** Aleeza Ahmad
- **Project Manager:** Oyku Cabuk
- **QA Tester / Documentation Specialist:** Berfu Emre

Project Overview & Background

The commuter college challenge is the main inspiration behind this project. At commuter-based institutions, students often come to campus for classes and leave immediately afterward, limiting opportunities to form social connections. As post-secondary students, events are crucial to create a sense of belonging and improve a student's experience.

Research further supports the connection between campus events and student retention. Steven Couras, director of residence life at Drew University states, "[students and their lack of involvement] often correlates with a weaker sense of belonging, which can play a significant role in retention" (Ezarik, 2024). The Canadian University Survey Consortium found that the older a student is, the less likely they are to have participated in clubs or attended events. The statistics showed that 26% of people were 21 and younger, and dropped to 3% for people over 30, highlighting students' lack of belonging (CUSC, 2021).

Furthermore, other universities also surveyed student involvement, such as Carleton and UofT, which support this claim. Studies show that 14% of students participate in clubs and 4% in campus events (Carleton, 2021). UofT, on the other hand, found 24.9% students attend campus activities and events. The reasoning behind this is simple: students lack awareness of such

events. According to Inside Higher Ed's Student Voice survey, around 31% of students lack knowledge about activities and events, causing them to not participate (College Club Critic, 2025). This proves that many students tend to miss events due to a lack of awareness and struggle to find a sense of belonging in these environments.

Why Existing Solutions Fail

- **Outlook/Blackboard:** Purely functional and lacks social interaction.
 - Blackboard UI can be less intuitive and costly compared to other platforms. Load times may be slow on Blackboard, as well as overwhelming features that can feel difficult for users. The vast options and tools can also lead to confusion or unintentional neglect of potentially useful features. (Luxwisp, 2025)
 - Outlook mails can get lost with the amount of emails regarding class assignments, job postings, announcements and more.
- **Eventbrite:** Too broad and doesn't verify student status, or filter by academic program.
 - Generic platforms like Eventbrite are robust for public event ticketing, but are not optimized for academic contexts as they don't filter by student program, verify student status, or integrate with campus systems.
 - These tools serve diverse event types (concerts, professional conferences, meetups), but lack campus-specific customization that students and administrators need for academic interest and community.
- **Social Media:** optimizing for "likes," not physical attendance or study groups.
 - Usually, many different accounts make it overwhelmingly difficult to navigate
 - Instagram: @senecapoly, @senecastudentlife, @senecassf
 - YouTube: Seneca Polytechnic, Seneca Student Federation
 - TikTok: @senecastudentlife, @senecassf (Seneca, 2026)

These findings demonstrate that although events and clubs exist across campuses, and different methods to spread awareness are available, students still struggle to discover opportunities that align with their interests or academic programs, especially in commuter college environments. StudentConnect aims to resolve this issue by making a centralized platform where events are organized and allowing students to navigate easily to find things that correlate with their interests.

Problem Statement & Need

Seneca's campus event environment is currently fragmented across multiple channels, such as posters, emails, and social media, creating an awareness gap where students struggle to consistently discover events that match their academic program (e.g., CPA, BSD) and personal interests. This issue is most strongly experienced by commuters and newly admitted students who often come to campus only for classes and leave immediately afterward, which limits opportunities to build friendships, peer networks, and a sense of belonging beyond the classroom. As a result, students face significant barriers in finding relevant activities and often feel discouraged or anxious about attending events alone, leading to lower engagement even when opportunities exist.

In contrast, student clubs, the Seneca Student Federation (SSF), and faculty organizers experience a "connection and outreach gap," where they cannot reliably promote events to the right student audiences (such as specific programs, interests, or semester cohorts) and have limited visibility into attendance outcomes. This issue is especially important because low involvement increases the risk of students dropping out. Research highlighted that six in ten students who left college reported not participating in any campus activities, compared to 35% of current students, indicating that low involvement is a major risk factor for student retention and success (Ezarik, 2024). Therefore, Seneca needs a centralized, student-focused platform that promotes event discovery, supports peer-to-peer connection through shared attendance, and provides organizers with meaningful participation insights to improve planning and impact.

Objectives

The primary objective of StudentConnect is to develop a centralized and secure web-based platform that increases campus event participation among Seneca students by reducing the fragmentation of event communication across multiple channels. By improving event visibility and relevance through personalization, the platform aims to support student engagement and contribute to a stronger sense of belonging within a commuter-based academic environment. Research consistently demonstrates that increased student involvement

in campus activities is strongly associated with improved retention and academic persistence (Ezarik, 2024; Modern Campus, 2025).

Specific Project Goals

At the current stage of development, StudentConnect focuses on providing a centralized space for campus events, allowing students to discover academic, social, and wellness activities through a single platform. The system incorporates personalized event recommendations based on students' academic programs and interests in order to address the widespread awareness gap identified in post-secondary institutions (College Club Critic, 2025). In addition, the platform includes an administrative dashboard that enables event organizers and administrators to manage events and analyze participation trends, supporting data-driven decision-making related to student engagement (CUSC, 2021).

Deliverables

The StudentConnect project will deliver a fully functional web-based system consisting of two primary interfaces. The student-facing portal will enable users to securely access a centralized catalogue of campus events and submit RSVPs through an intuitive interface. In parallel, an administrative portal will be provided for authorized users to create and manage events, monitor attendance, and review engagement metrics through structured dashboards.

Supporting these interfaces is a personalization and recommendation component that aligns students with relevant events based on program affiliation and expressed interests. The platform is underpinned by a relational database architecture designed to securely manage user profiles, event data, and RSVP records while ensuring scalability, data integrity, and controlled access for administrative reporting.

Why is this a Substantial Two-Semester Project?

Scope & Complexity

This project exceeds a single semester's scope because it requires developing two distinct, fully functional software products, consisting of the student view and admin view that interact with a complex backend. To execute this, the team must coordinate across specialized technical roles simultaneously. **Database Administrators** must manage the relational schema for user data, **Backend Developers** need to engineer the recommendation algorithms and API logic, **Frontend/UI Designers** must ensure accessibility across devices, and **QA/Documentation Specialists** must validate the system against business requirements. Integrating these features into a working project requires a disciplined, multi-phase approach.

Phased Implementation Roadmap

Semester 1: Foundation & Core Architecture

- **Phase 1: Planning & Design (Weeks 1-6)**
 - Defining the Business Requirements Document (BRD) and Use Cases.
 - Designing the Entity Relationship Diagram (ERD) for the complex Many-to-Many relationships (Users ↔ Events ↔ Tags).
 - UI/UX Wireframing for both Student and Admin portals.
- **Phase 2: Core Development (Weeks 7-14)**
 - **Authentication:** Implementing secure login using simulated SSO and Role-Based Access Control (RBAC) to distinguish between Students, Club Leaders, and Super Admins.
 - **Designing the Website:** Creating a working prototype, allowing users to interact with the website and view events.
 - **Event CRUD:** Building the foundational API to Create, Read, Update, and Delete events.

- **MVP Release:** A functional prototype allowing basic event filtering by Program (CPA/BSD).

Semester 2: Intelligence, Social Features & Optimization

- **Phase 3: Advanced Logic Implementation (Weeks 1-7)**
 - **The "Connection" Engine:** Developing the backend algorithm that suggests "Students you might know" or "Events for you" based on historical user behaviour.
 - **Community Features:** Implementing real-time communication sockets for event-specific discussion threads.
- **Phase 4: Analytics & Testing (Weeks 8-14)**
 - **Data Visualization:** Integrating libraries to generate administrative reports, such as "**Most Popular Event Categories**" and "**Weekly Registration Trends**" to help the SSF understand student interests.
 - **System Optimization:** Testing to manage high-traffic scenarios (e.g., 50 students booking a slot simultaneously) and final User Acceptance Testing (UAT).

References

- Careleton. (2021). *2021 Canadian University Survey Consortium (CUSC) Graduating Undergraduate Students*. Carleton University.
https://oirp.carleton.ca/surveys/CUSC2021_summary.pdf
- College Club Critic. (2025, October 19). *Uncovering the Campus Involvement Crisis: A Student Guide*. College Club Critic | Discover & Review Campus Clubs Nationwide.
<https://www.collegeclubcritic.com/the-hidden-crisis-in-campus-involvement/>
- CUSC. (2021). *Graduating Student Survey Master Report 2021*. Canadian University Survey Consortium.
https://www.ssc.uwo.ca/pdf_folder/about/CUSC_2021-Graduating-Student-Survey_Master-Report-English.pdf
- Ezarik, M. (2024, December 10). *Could campus activity involvement keep students in college?*. Inside Higher Ed | Higher Education News, Events and Jobs.
<https://www.insidehighered.com/news/student-success/college-experience/2024/12/10/could-campus-activity-involvement-keep-students>
- Luxwisp. (2025, September 16). *20 pros and cons of blackboard*. Ablison.
<https://www.luxwisp.com/pros-and-cons-of-blackboard/>
- Modern Campus. (2025). *How student engagement can make or break your retention rate*.
<https://moderncampus.com/blog/how-student-engagement-boosts-success-retention.html>
- Seneca. (2026). *Seneca's social media accounts*. Seneca Service Hub.
<https://theservicehub.senecapolytechnic.ca/s/article/Seneca-social-media-accounts>
- UofT. (2018). *National Survey of Student Engagement (NSSE)*. University of Toronto.
<https://governingcouncil.utoronto.ca/system/files/ogc/agendas/a1119-3i-2018-2019uab.pdf>
- Wikipedia. (2024). *Seneca Polytechnic*.
https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Seneca_Polytechnic